

Lesson 12:

Defining "Surah"

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Unlike in common translations, "surah" is not a chapter; rather it is unique terminology unparalleled in any other literature. Ustadh Nouman goes over the root letters, origin, meaning and profound implications of the word "surah."

- Allah says in the Quran that he didn't reveal just ayahs, he actually says he revealed "surahs". In Surah An-Nur, Allah actually calls it a surah. (24:1)

سُورَةٌ أَنْزَلْنَاهَا وَفَرَضْنَاهَا وَأَنْزَلْنَا فِيهَا آيَاتٍ بَيِّنَاتٍ لَّعَلَّكُمْ تَذَكَّرُونَ

- سَوْرَ - When you have a wine or a liquor that's extremely heavy or strong, which will intoxicate just after a few sips. The intensity that reaches/affects the head is what this word means.
- سَارَ يَسُورُ - To climb up to a very high place. This word was used to describe the tall walls that would protect a city and were insurmountable.
- تَسَوَّرَ - To scale.
- سَوْرَةٌ - A high status, a level of a building, borders of something.
- A surah can remind you of another surah or of another piece of a surah.
- "Surah" is used to describe something that rises from the bottom to the top. Like the drink that intoxicates you from the bottom to the top, the wall that's insurmountable, etc.
- The Quran actually uses the word "surah" as something that's dropped down, instead of something being raised from the bottom to the top. That means that it is impossible to surmount because you cannot see the top, it is endless. And if you can't see the top then it's not prone to attack. This is Allah's way of saying that the Quran can't be attacked.